



CARIC DESIGN: Rami

Everywhere

From the minute we wake up to the time we go to sleep, technology touches us in many ways. A look at how technology is entrenched in our lives

Family ties



Kumar residence, Andheri

Roop Kumar wakes up to the sound of the alarm set on his cell phone. It's a custom ring tone based on a song from his favourite movie *Dil Chahta Hai*, which he downloaded two days ago. By 7 am, the Kumar residence is bustling with activity, with the usual battles for the bathroom and squabbles over breakfast. Roop decides to get some work out of the way and retires to his PDA where he schedules his meetings and plans the day ahead of him.

While Roop is the man of the house, when it comes to the PC, it's his 19-year-old son Atul who gets the upper hand. "I'm not very good with the PC, but my son tinkers with it all the time. He was the one who figured out how to hook the MP3 player to the car," says Roop, while

his son uploads a new set of songs into their MP3 player. He's also the one to hook up his audio

system to his PC, while his comparatively underpowered computer speakers gather dust on the table.

"I usually spend late nights surfing and downloading, even though my connection lets me be online all the time," says Atul. His Cable Net connection gives above average speeds late in the night, a development that has changed his body clock and sleeping hours. His computer's on all day, leeching off MP3s from P2P applications. Three songs are being downloaded at speeds of less than half a kilobyte per second while 14 more are in queue. "When I used a modem, I used to hog the land-line and the phone bills were a nightmare. Now it's bye-bye to dial-up connections and extravagant phone bills! For Rs 800 a month, I'm connected to the Net all the time!" says Atul in a voice filled with glee.

A couple of years ago, the PC was exclusively Atul's domain, but now the rest of the family is just as involved. "It's become too easy. Supriya's on the messenger all the time with her friends. It's one of the reasons why I want to switch to Linux,"

he complains. "I'd like to have another PC and network it to this one," he adds. "There are so many old parts lying around the house. We have a spare monitor and a Pentium 100 MHz—I could easily get another PC up and running. I just need some extra RAM and a new hard disk."

"I've spent over a lakh and a half on the PC in the last year," sighs Roop as he peers through his bifocals at the monitor. Right now he is mailing himself some files, which he can later access at the office. Simultaneously, he looks up the headlines and checks the latest stock quotes at the Mumbai Sensex. With online stock trading, it's been such a long time since he actually needed to talk to his share broker. "It's my new habit. I keep checking the stock quotes of my portfolio whenever I get some free time. I never close the window; I just click Refresh every few minutes, even at work," he says.

Office hours



Roop Kumar's office, Nariman Point

While sipping on his first cup →

THE CAST

Father: Roop Kumar
Mother: Hema Kumar
Daughter: Supriya Kumar
Son: Atul Kumar